seven hostages including women, children, and Rupin Katyal, the one passenger that had been killed, were offloaded. The plane was then taken to the Taliban's stronghold, Kandahar, on the morning of Christmas day. Lacking diplomatic relations meant that no Indian official was immediately available to engage with the Taliban and negotiate with the hijackers. But soon after, India dispatched MEA Joint Secretary (Pakistan-Afghanistan-Iran) Vivek Katju, senior Intelligence Bureau (IB) officials Ajit Doval and Nehchal Sandhu, and senior R&AW officials C. D. Sahay and some more intelligence officials to Kandahar to negotiate. While the Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS), India's highest decision-making body on security, called the final shots; EAM Jaswant Singh dealt with the crisis in real-time with R&AW chief Amarjit Singh Dulat briefing him regularly. The UN, for its part, sent Erick de Mul, the UNDP chief in Pakistan, as an observer and negotiator, who convinced the Taliban to ensure the safety of passengers in the plane.

From the Taliban's side, Mullah Omar (*Amir-ul-Momineen*), Mullah Akhtar Mansour (civil aviation minister), Mullah Wakil Ahmad Muttawakil (foreign minister), and Mullah Akhtar Mohammad Usmani (military chief of Kandahar who controlled the airport) called the shots. Allegedly, in the shadows, at the airport, were ISI officials.[131] In fact, according to Sahay, the ISI supported the operation actively throughout the incident (including in Kathmandu), and managed it from Karachi, just like the 2008 attacks in Mumbai.[132] Such was the ISI's influence on the Taliban, in Sahay's assessment, that the latter had handed over the control tower to the ISI operatives to carry out negotiations with the Indian team. Moreover, while initially the Taliban refused to allow the plane to land in Kabul, it changed its position once advised by the ISI that it was their operation to secure the release of HuA leadership.[133] The negotiations lasted eight days with India securing freedom for all passengers and crew at the cost of releasing three top militants: Masood Azhar (who created the *Jaish-e-Mohammad*, JeM, within weeks of his release and was an important go-between the AQ and the ISI),[134] Omar Saeed Sheikh (later arrested in Pakistan for the alleged kidnapping and murder of American journalist Daniel Pearl), and Mushtaq Ahmad Zargar (responsible for running militant training camps from Pakistan-administered Kashmir).[135] Having no relations with the Taliban till